

DECODED EXPLAINED

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The Hurdles ChatGPT for Teens Safeguards Could Run Into in India

The many hurdles ChatGPT for Teens safeguards could run into for Indian users

Anagha Jayakumar
New Delhi, August 30

OPENAI RECENTLY announced the launch of a version of ChatGPT exclusively for teenage users.

Teenagers are already using ChatGPT extensively, with OpenAI saying nearly nine in 10 teens turn to it for learning, information, skill-building or productivity in a week. But their growing use of AI tools has also spurred concerns over how these systems respond to young users, particularly when conversations move beyond homework or information-seeking into emotional support, mental health and companionship.

Crucially, the new offering is not a separate application or website. Teenagers continue to use the regular ChatGPT, but with additional, age-appropriate features built in. These are automatically enabled when a user's stated or verified age, or OpenAI's age-prediction system, indicates that they are under 18. OpenAI does not allow children below age 13 to use ChatGPT.

Establishing user age

According to OpenAI, it uses information associated with an account, including a user's stated or verified age, as well as an age-prediction system that looks at signals such as how long the account has existed, the times of day it is typically used, general conversation topics, and patterns of use.

In India, the relationship between a device, an account and the person using it is not always straightforward. The RATT Foundation's Ideal Internet 3.0 study, released in November 2025, found that 62% of Indian teenagers surveyed used shared devices. Moreover, 42% reported that other people operated their social media accounts, while 56% said they could log into someone else's.

The 62% figure was acknowledged in OpenAI's Teen Safety Blueprint for India, released this January. While this does not directly imply that teenagers are using shared ChatGPT accounts, it raises questions for a system attempting to determine the age of the person behind an account.

Pragya Misra, Head of Strategy & Global

Affairs, OpenAI India, told *The Indian Express* that ChatGPT for Teens is designed around the account rather than the device. This means that if a teenager and an adult use separate accounts on the same shared device, each can receive the experience appropriate to their age.

"It is not intended to distinguish between multiple people using the same shared account or to switch experiences person by person within one login," Misra said of the age-prediction system. When uncertain about a user's age, OpenAI defaults to the under-18 experience.

Potential pitfalls

A risk assessment undertaken by Common Sense Media, an independent media watchdog for content consumed by children, and Stanford Medicine's Brainstorm Lab for Mental Health Innovation found that leading AI chatbots failed to recognise and appropri-

ately respond to mental health conditions affecting young people.

Robbie Torney, Head of AI and Digital Assessments at Common Sense, told *The Indian Express* that meaningful testing of safeguards requires "testing the product that teens are using, not a model in isolation over an API". Traditional benchmarks, he pointed out, are often based on collections of single-turn conversations, which do not necessarily capture how teenagers interact with these products.

The assessment found that chatbots frequently missed warning signs of mental health distress, including when users disclosed them indirectly.

The researchers also found a marked difference between isolated prompts and longer interactions: while safeguards performed better when presented with explicit, single-turn prompts, they became

less reliable over extended conversations that more closely resembled how young people might actually use a chatbot.

The Common Sense-Stanford assessment also warned that the features that make chatbots engaging, including empathetic responses, follow-up questions and memory, could encourage young users to rely on them for emotional support when human intervention may be necessary.

Asked whether OpenAI had tested the teen experience over sustained interactions, Misra said ChatGPT for Teens was supported by "ongoing safety research, red-teaming, evaluations, and adversarial testing", including teen-specific evaluations covering self-harm, eating disorders, violence, age-restricted goods and services, and sexual content.

"The experience also includes proportionate break prompts during unusually long, active sessions, along with safeguards designed to reinforce real-world support and reduce emotional dependence," she said.

Different user needs

OpenAI has acknowledged that safety features designed for Indian teenagers may run into a unique set of challenges. The Teen Safety Blueprint for India notes that Indian teenagers often access technology in "shared, multilingual and mediated contexts", rather than through the single-user, private devices many safety tools assume.

The RATT report notes that this divide is amplified in rural and low-income contexts. Only half of the teenagers surveyed had a personal email ID, compared with 28% among rural low-income teenagers.

This divide matters because how some of the additional safeguards work. Parents can link their ChatGPT account to their teenager's through an email invitation, after which they can set quiet hours, manage certain settings and receive safety notifications. This could put teenagers in lower-access households at a disadvantage in using these parental controls.

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A weekly column decoding AI's new frontiers, how they shape the world and our place in it

The Hurdles ChatGPT for Teens Safeguards Could Run Into in India

- **AI Therapy**

- **Advantages**

- **User or Patient**

- **Access without travel or waitlists:** against 0.75 psychiatrists per lakh population, round-the-clock chatbot support reaches people the system otherwise cannot, as with Wysa's rural-adolescent programme in India.
 - **Lower cost and less stigma:** free tools substitute for sessions costing eight hundred to two thousand rupees, and an anonymous interface often becomes the first step for someone unwilling to see a counsellor.

- **Clinician and Mental Health System**

- **A force multiplier:** triage, mood tracking, and administrative automation free up therapist time for complex cases.

- **Technology Provider or Platform**

- **Scale, data, and market position:** a genuine public-health opportunity exists for firms building clinically grounded tools,

- **Government and Regulator**

- **A lever to widen public mental health access:** AI tools can extend psychoeducation and early screening to populations that ASHA workers and primary health centres alone cannot cover at the same scale.

- **Society at Large**

- **Normalised help-seeking:** wider, less stigmatised access to basic mental health support can shift public attitudes over time.

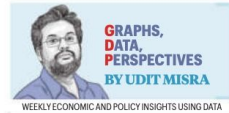
The Hurdles ChatGPT for Teens Safeguards Could Run Into in India

- **AI Therapy**
 - **Issues**
 - **User or Patient**
 - Harmful guidance and dependency
 - **Clinician and Mental Health System**
 - Diluted clinical judgment and liability exposure
 - **Technology Provider or Platform**
 - Legal and reputational liability
 - **Government and Regulator**
 - A regulatory vacuum: standards for clinical validation, data protection, and minor consent remain unsettled in India,
 - **Society at Large**
 - Deepened inequity and isolation: the same rural and low-literacy groups who stand to gain most are also least likely to have smartphones or stable data, so the digital divide can widen rather than close.
 - Algorithmic bias compounds this: Wysa's own need for a separate co-design study for rural Indian adolescent girls admits that its default model under-serves them.
 - **Way ahead**
 - Clinicians need integration protocols that keep a human in the loop by default, with automatic escalation on any risk signal.
 - Society needs bias testing and inclusive design so that access gains are not cancelled out by the digital divide

Worries Behind India's Robust GDP, Inflation Data

Worries behind India's robust GDP, inflation data

Six months after the war in West Asia broke out, the Indian economy appears to be holding up. But several risks to growth remain.



GRAPHS,
DATA,
PERSPECTIVES
BY UDIT MISRA

WEEKLY ECONOMIC AND POLICY INSIGHTS USING DATA

OVER THE past three financial years, the Indian economy recorded a GDP (gross domestic product) growth rate of more than 7%, alongside a sharp drop in the inflation rate. Many analysts expected the US-Israeli War on Iran to dent this trajectory, owing to factors like an increase in the prices of crude oil and a reduction in foreign investments. Making matters worse was the prospect of high temperatures thanks to El Niño, which threatened to hit food production.

The growth rate was expected to fall, while the inflation rate was expected to skyrocket from 2% in 2025-26 to near 6% — from the lower end of RBI's "comfort zone" to its upper limit. On May 11, Prime Minister Narendra Modi even appealed to Indians to tighten their belts by stopping gold purchases and reducing fuel consumption, among other measures.

But macroeconomic data shows India hasn't fared as poorly as feared. On Monday, GDP data for Q1 will be released and is expected to yet again cross the 7% mark.

Resilient economy?

Six months since the war began, the GDP growth rate, inflation rate, and current account balance do not show the impairment initially feared.

A research note from HSBC states: "Growth remains high, inflation remains low, and the current account deficit surprisingly contained. Headline numbers across the board feel more goldilocks than crisis."

"Goldilocks" refers to a term analysts used at the start of the year to describe the economy, referring to an optimal state of affairs. The term, however, quickly lost favour once the West Asia war exposed persistent weaknesses in the Indian economy, best captured by the sharp fall in the rupee's exchange rate. As such, it makes sense to examine whether the economy has genuinely returned to a "Goldilocks" scenario or if the data hides risks.

On GDP growth

In a detailed note, HSBC economists led by Pranjal Bhandari have explained both scenarios — why India's macros did not worsen as much as expected, and the

triggers that could make the picture worse.

HSBC's 100-indicators of growth database points towards India's GDP growing by 7.75% during the first quarter (April, May and June). SBI's research team has gone a step further, projecting an 8% growth.

What's driving this? Some of it can be ascribed to the 125-basis point cut in the repo rate between December 2024 and December 2025. The repo rate is the interest rate at which the RBI lends money to commercial banks. A lower repo rate makes it cheaper for banks to borrow money from the RBI and, in turn, cheaper for individuals and businesses to borrow from commercial banks. Cheaper loans incentivise economic activity, thus boosting growth. Often the "transmission" of a repo rate cut takes a couple of quarters to show up as faster GDP growth.

Another factor could be the effect of cuts in Goods and Services Tax in 2025. Lower tax rates reduced prices and improved people's purchasing power, resulting in higher economic activity. Yet another factor noted by HSBC economists is the rise of India's exports to the US as Donald Trump's tariffs were removed. Lastly, evidence suggests that manufacturers front-loaded production as they were anxious about future energy availability.

On inflation, CAD

First, while the monthly retail inflation rate — the rate at which the general price level went up over the year — has moved up since October, it is still well-contained and near the RBI's target level of 4% (see chart). Often, inflation remains muted be-

Heavy lifter

HSBC researchers argue that it is the services sector that is saving India the blushes as of now.

Accounting for 55% of India's GDP, the sector heavily affects where growth and inflation will land and how external deficits will be contained.

cause growth is muted. In this case, however, inflation has remained muted despite supply pressures, as well as demand holding up fairly well.

Secondly, the current account refers to the net amount of money flowing in or out of India as it trades (exports and imports) goods and services with the world. Typically, when the GDP is growing fast, or when imports are getting costlier, the country imports more than it exports, leading to a trade deficit. It translates into the outflow of billions of dollars.

What India often earns from exports of services (like software services) as well as from remittances from Indians working abroad is not enough to make up for the dollars India shells out for imports, in general. The net result is called a current account deficit (CAD). But despite fast growth and costlier imports, India's CAD too has remained fairly muted. "The headline c/a deficit is low at 0.3% of GDP as per RBI's aggregated monthly data, and not showing signs of excesses," note HSBC economists (see chart).

Reading the numbers

While macro indicators look counter-intuitively robust on the face of it, risks to growth and inflation persist.

On growth, HSBC researchers state that a lot of the credit growth (increased loans) has been driven by factors such as "(t)he new government credit guarantee scheme for small firms, the rise in working capital needs spurred by higher commodity prices, and the proliferation of gold loan growth (which can sometimes be seen as

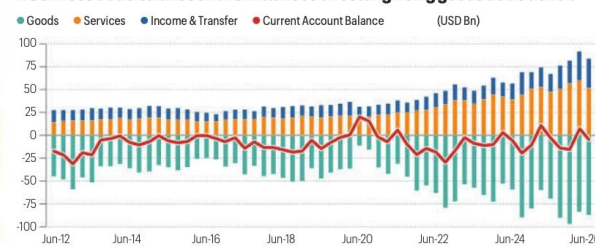
an indicator of stress)". Moreover, the front-loading of manufacturing could be followed by a lull, and agricultural growth could weaken if the El Niño strengthens.

On inflation, the overall benign levels hide fairly divergent trends. HSBC Research stated that food inflation and non-food goods inflation are already averaging 5.4% (year-on-year) in July (see chart). What is holding back the headline inflation from surging is that services have remained "remarkably low at 2.5%". Therein lies the risk. "Low services inflation data is keeping headline (rate) contained. If it rises from here, reflecting growth better, headline inflation numbers could rise quickly," notes HSBC.

Similarly, on CAD, a closer look at the chart shows that it is low as of now because even though the goods trade deficit is growing, rising services exports and remittances are offsetting the rise in the trade deficit. HSBC states, "Given the uncertainties around the impact of AI on services exports growth, one needs to be careful on how long services can fund a rising goods deficit. Already, services exports have grown at a slower pace this year."

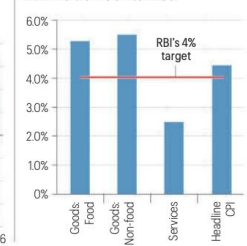
Few expected India to survive this phase of global disruption without taking a big hit. HSBC researchers argue that it is the services sector that is saving India the blushes as of now. Accounting for 55% of India's GDP, the sector plays a crucial role in determining where growth will land, how long inflation will remain low, and until when external deficits will be contained. If services inflation goes up and services exports take a hit, the RBI may be forced to raise interest rates, which could dampen growth.

1. Services trade balance and remittances offsetting rising goods trade deficit



SOURCE: CEIC, HSBC

2. Inflation contained



Worries Behind India's Robust GDP, Inflation Data

- **Goldilocks Economy?**
 - A Goldilocks economy represents an ideal economic condition where there is balanced growth, low inflation, and full employment, without overheating or slipping into a recession.
- **India's real GDP grew 7.8% in Q1 FY 2026-27**
- **What are the factors ensuring growth ?**
 - **Strong private consumption:** Household consumption (which makes up nearly 60% of the economy)
 - **Higher government capital expenditure:** The government allocated ₹12.22 lakh crore for capital expenditure in FY2026-27
 - **Surge in Investment**
 - **Strong manufacturing growth**
 - **Robust services sector:** The tertiary sector continues to expand rapidly, led by financial services, real estate, travel, and Global Capability Centers (GCCs) setting up tech hubs in the country
 - **Resilient exports**
- **Challenges to the growth ?**
 - **Geopolitical tensions and energy shock**
 - **Uneven Monsoon Distribution**
 - **Global trade uncertainties**
 - **Employment generation**
 - **Climate change and environmental pressures**
- **Way ahead : Productivity-driven, employment-intensive and inclusive growth**

Worries Behind India's Robust GDP, Inflation Data

In the context of the Indian economy, consider the following pairs :

Term	Most appropriate description
1. Meltdown	Fall in stock prices
2. Recession	Fall in growth rate
3. Slow down	Fall in GDP

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

This question was previously asked in

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1. 1 only

2. 2 and 3 only

3. 1 and 3 only

4. 1, 2 and 3

Nancy Grace Roman Telescope

Nancy Grace Roman Telescope



A computer generated model of the Nancy Grace Roman Telescope. NASA

Reuters

NASA is preparing to launch its next flagship space observatory — one scientists plan to use to investigate some of the universe's biggest mysteries, including dark energy and dark matter, while also testing gravity at vast scales and hunting for planets beyond our solar system.

The Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope is a roughly \$4-billion project. At the time of writing, it was planned for a Sunday launch from the NASA Kennedy Space Center in Florida. The observatory will be lofted into orbit aboard a SpaceX Falcon Heavy rocket. The telescope is named after the late Nancy Grace Roman, NASA's first chief astronomer.

It is a follow-on to the Hubble Space Telescope, launched in 1990, and the James Webb Space Telescope, launched in 2021, and has capabilities that can expand on the knowledge gained by those pioneering observatories, both of which also still operate. The telescope's

main survey will take more than a year, per Roman's senior project scientist Julie McEnery.

"The survey will contain over two billion galaxies and enable us to study how the structures in our universe — the stars, the galaxies, the clusters of galaxies — grew and evolved. We'll also measure how our universe has expanded over time," she said.

After launch and separation from the rocket, the telescope will travel towards a location called Lagrange point 2, about 1.6 million km from the earth. Webb also resides at this location.

U.S. President Donald Trump tried during both his first and second terms to reduce or eliminate funding for Roman but the Congress preserved it.

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Beta Pictoris b: Hide and Seek

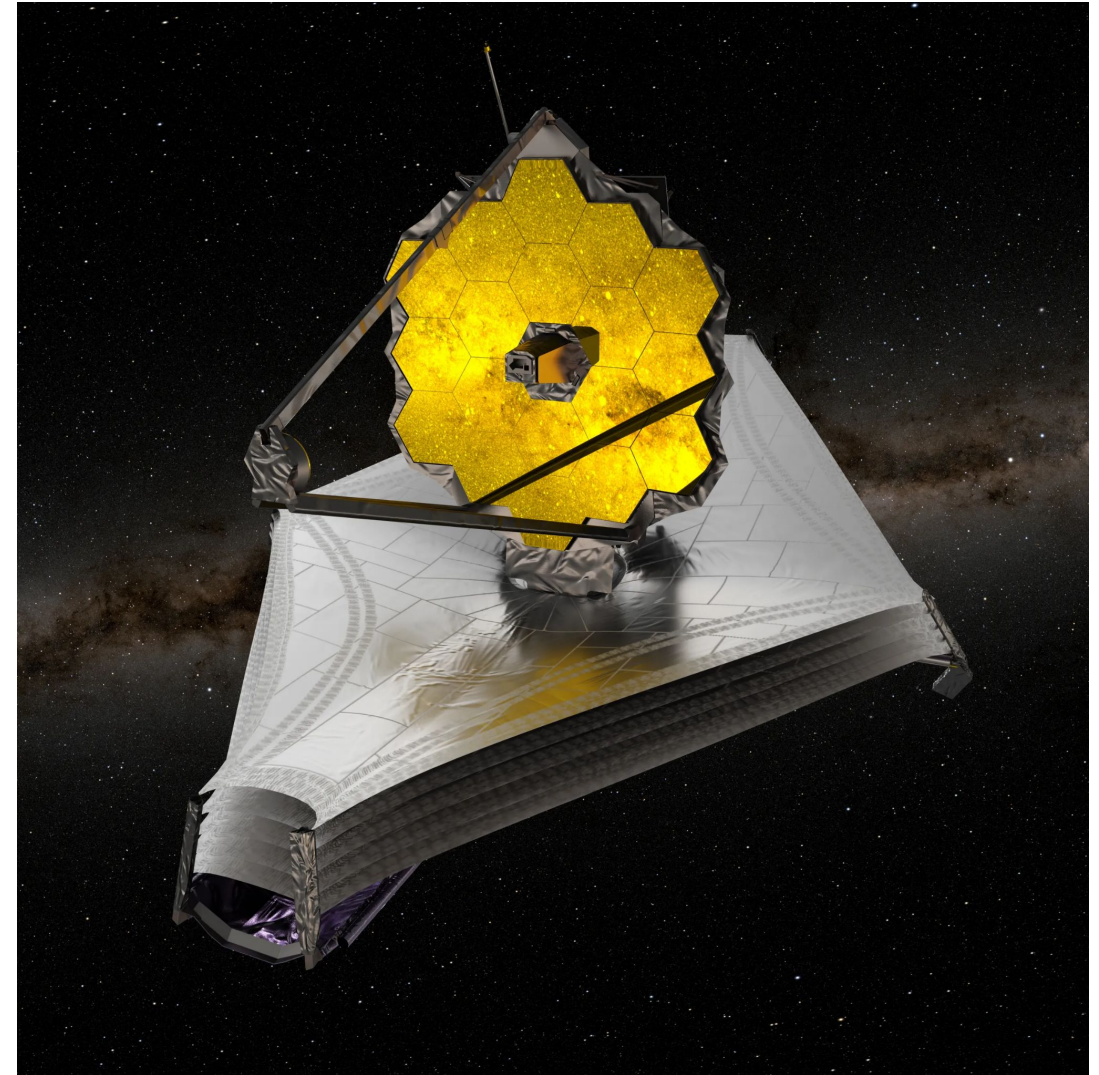
James Webb Telescope

The James Webb Space Telescope (JWST) is a monumental leap in space exploration and astrophysics.

Launched on December 25, 2021, it is the largest and most powerful space telescope ever built, serving as the premier space-based observatory for the next decade.

Developed by NASA with contributions from the European and Canadian space agencies, JWST is designed to observe the universe primarily in the infrared spectrum.

Successor to Hubble: It has been conceived as the next-generation space telescope succeeding the Hubble Space Telescope, with a focus on infrared astronomy



Beta Pictoris b: Hide and Seek

Infrared optimisation: Designed primarily for infrared astronomy to observe objects which were too old, distant, or faint for visible light detection.

Large primary mirror: Equipped with a 6.5-meter diameter primary mirror to capture more light and provide higher-resolution images.

Segmented mirror design: The primary mirror comprises 18 hexagonal, gold-coated beryllium segments, thus enabling it to fold for launch and unfold in space.

Sunshield protection: A five-layer sun-shield, which blocks solar light and heat, maintaining the instruments at extremely low temperatures necessary for infrared observations.

Location at Lagrange Point 2 (L2): Operates from a stable orbit around the Sun-Earth L2 point thereby minimising light interference and reducing fuel consumption for orbital corrections.

High sensitivity: Its instruments are highly sensitive to infrared light thus enabling the study of the earliest stars and galaxies formed after the Big Bang.

Cryogenic cooling system: Uses a passive cooling system to reach temperatures as low as 40 Kelvin (-233°C) which is essential for infrared observations.

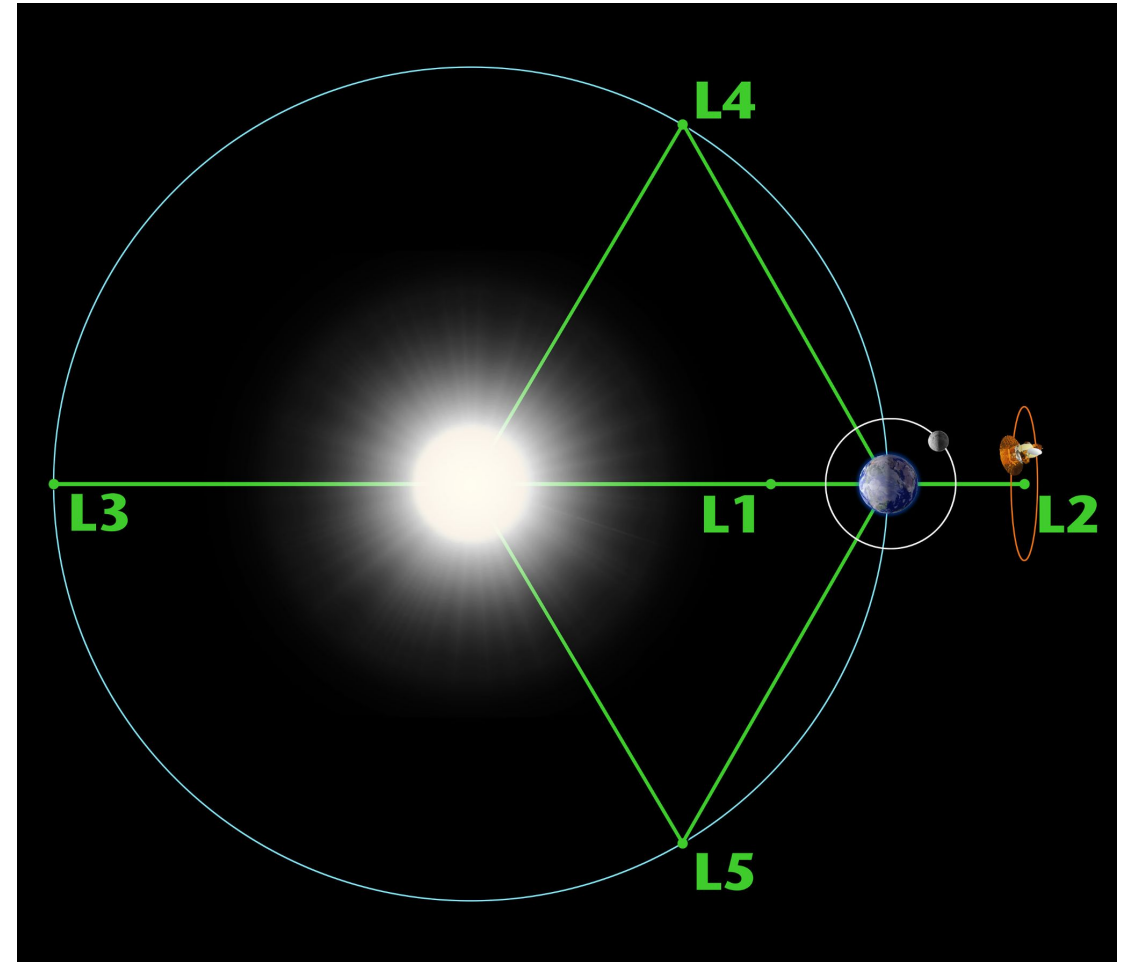
Precision guidance sensors: Equipped with sophisticated guidance sensors for accurate pointing and stability. This is crucial for long-duration observations of faint celestial objects.

Beta Pictoris b: Hide and Seek

Lagrange Points are special positions in space where objects placed there tend to stay in a stable or nearly stable position.

Spacecraft placed at these points require very little fuel to remain in position, making them extremely useful for satellites, telescopes, and space observatories.

Of the five Lagrange points, three are unstable and two are stable. The unstable Lagrange points - labeled L1, L2 and L3 - lie along the line connecting the two large masses. The stable Lagrange points - labeled L4 and L5 - form the apex of two equilateral triangles that have the large masses at their vertices.



Beta Pictoris b: Hide and Seek

The James Webb Space Telescope (JWST) offers numerous benefits for humanity in various ways:

- Advancing astrophysical knowledge
- Exoplanet exploration
- Educational and scientific collaboration
- Catalyst for future space missions

James Webb Space Telescope (JWST)	Hubble Space Telescope.
Optimized for infrared astronomy, allowing it to see through dust clouds and view redshifted light of distant galaxies.	Predominantly observed in the visible and ultraviolet light bands.
Has a primary mirror 6.5 meters in diameter.	Has a primary mirror 2.4 meters in diameter.
Far more light-gathering capability and resolution, enabling the detection of fainter and more distant objects.	Less light-gathering capability and resolution compared to James Webb Space Telescope.
Located at the second Lagrange point (L2), providing a more stable vantage point and uninterrupted sky observation.	In low Earth orbit, which is less stable than L2.

Nancy Grace Roman Telescope

- **The mission will complement the capabilities of the Hubble Space Telescope (launched in 1990) and the James Webb Space Telescope (launched in 2021) by conducting wider and deeper surveys of the universe.**
- **Will operate near the Sun-Earth Lagrange Point 2 (L2), about 1.6 million km from Earth.**
- **Equipped with a 300-megapixel Wide Field Instrument (infrared camera), Roman will survey vast regions of space, study over two billion galaxies, and examine the evolution of cosmic structures.**
- **The telescope will measure how the universe has expanded over time and investigate the role of dark energy in shaping cosmic evolution.**
- **Unlike the James Webb Space Telescope, which trades panoramic views for a narrow field of view to peer deeply into small, specific patches of the sky, Roman is built for scale. Its field of view is 100 times larger than the Hubble Space Telescope's, meaning that in just the five years of its primary scheduled mission,**

Unlocking Soft Power With Saptadhara

Unlocking soft power with Saptadhara



C V ANANDA
BOSE

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi introduced Saptadhara from the Red Fort on August 15. This concept includes seven streams of national strength that can help India achieve its *Viksit Bharat* goal. One of these is soft power. Coined by Joseph S Nye Jr, soft power is about influencing others through admiration instead of coercion. India has a wealth of soft power, including a long civilisational history, rich cultural diversity, and a strong tradition of knowledge. Yoga connects people worldwide with India. Ayurveda provides a philosophy of wellness. Our spiritual centres draw people seeking peace, and our festivals celebrate harmony and renewal. Indian literature, music, dance, and cinema transcend languages. Our cuisine is recognised globally. Handicrafts and handlooms reflect the skill and creativity of generations. India's democracy, scientific progress, digital systems, space programme, and global diaspora further enhance its global reputation.

However, India lacks a coherent system to turn its cultural assets into influence, economic value, and sustainable livelihoods. Having cultural wealth doesn't guarantee global influence, and appreciation won't ensure income for artistes or knowledge-holders. The Saptadhara vision offers a chance to fix this gap.

Each district should create a soft power and creative economy plan. This plan should identify local artists, artisans, writers, and cultural workers. It should connect them to training, technology, finance, intellectual property protection, local markets, and international opportunities. Experienced practitioners should mentor young apprentices. The *guru-shishya* system should receive modern support while staying authentic. Schools and universities should introduce students to India's cultural diversity.

Soft power can drive significant employment. Areas like tourism, cinema, music, fashion, and education can create millions of jobs. The government should enable this growth. It should invest initially, set standards, connect markets, and be a first customer when possible. Cultural workers should not rely solely on grants but should be empowered to earn regular incomes.

A national mission can aim to create 1 crore new jobs in tourism, arts, media, and the creative economy. Districts should prepare soft-power employment plans. Indian missions abroad should facilitate market access and promote Indian culture and businesses. Success should be measured by real livelihoods created and opportunities gained. Missions can help creators secure opportunities for touring, publishing, and international collaboration. Young people must be central to this movement. They should become creators and innovators. By blending heritage with technology, young Indians can share their stories and cultures with the world through digital platforms and new industries.

India does not need to create soft power; it should enhance, connect, and protect it. The path forward should be clear: *Kala* (art) to *kaushal* (skill), *kamai* (earning) to *rozgar* (employment), *bazaar* (market) to *vishwa prabhav* (global influence). Saptadhara can ensure that those who preserve traditions receive dignified livelihoods and that youth inherit both identity and opportunity. This way, India's cultural voice will confidently reach the world.

The writer is former governor of West Bengal

India does not
need to create
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Unlocking Soft Power With Saptadhara



Manufacturing: Transform India into a global manufacturing and supply-chain hub by focusing on cost competitiveness, quality, scale, precision, components and finished products.

Farming & Food Processing: Connect farms with global markets by leveraging FTAs and promoting Indian millets, spices, fruits, vegetables and traditional foods as global brands.

Technology & Innovation: Position India as a hub for data centres, robotics, emerging technologies and next-generation communications, building on the success of UPI and Digital Public Infrastructure and advancing indigenous 6G.

Gati Shakti & Connectivity: Accelerate seamless, high-speed multimodal connectivity through roads, expressways, high-speed rail and port-led development to reduce logistics constraints.

Raksha Shakti: Strengthen Atma Nirbhar defence manufacturing, with emphasis on drones, counter-drone systems and next-generation defence technologies, while developing India as a global defence supplier.

Green & Blue Economy: Pursue global leadership in green hydrogen, renewable energy and energy storage, while tapping the Blue Economy through fisheries, coastal tourism and ocean technologies.

Soft Power: Expand India's global cultural influence through Yoga, handicrafts, films, animation, gaming, digital content, tourism and the creative economy.

Typhoid Control Needs More Vaccine, Less Antibiotic



KAMINI WALIA

EVERYONE IS talking about increasing influenza and swine flu cases. Another disease where cases are unobtrusively mounting is typhoid. This should concern us, not simply because typhoid remains a common infection, but because every suspected case can become a trigger for inappropriate or unnecessarily broad-spectrum antibiotic use.

Typhoid presents a particularly difficult paradox. It is a vaccine-preventable bacterial disease, yet in India we continue to diagnose it imperfectly and treat it empirically. The fundamental problem is the absence of a simple, reliable, accessible diagnostic test. A single Widal test is not sufficient to establish

a diagnosis of acute typhoid. In an endemic country such as India, background antibodies and previous exposure or vaccination can make interpretation difficult. Yet, in routine practice, a positive Widal result may still be treated as confirmation of typhoid.

Blood culture remains the conventional laboratory standard, but it too has limitations. The WHO's latest typhoid guidance notes that the sensitivity of a single blood culture is only around 55-60 per cent, with yield influenced by the volume of blood collected and, critically, prior antimicrobial exposure. This creates a vicious cycle: A patient develops prolonged fever, takes an antibiotic before seeking care, undergoes blood culture, and receives a negative result. The clinician is left with suspicion but no microbiological confirmation — and may respond by escalating or changing antibiotics.

The result is an antimicrobial-resistance (AMR) problem. In a country already struggling with increasing resistance to *Salmonella typhi*, every unnecessary antibiotic course creates additional selection pressure, while every missed diagnosis undermines surveillance of resistance patterns. But there is another question we should be asking: Why are we trying to solve a vaccine-preventable disease primarily through antibiotics? India is one of the countries where the case for typhoid

It is a vaccine-preventable bacterial disease, yet in India we continue to diagnose it imperfectly and treat it empirically

vaccination is compelling. The WHO has prioritised typhoid-conjugate vaccine (TCV) introduction in countries with high disease-burden or high AMR levels. India produced the world's first WHO-prequalified TCV, Typbar-TCV, in 2017. Since then, additional Indian TCV products have achieved WHO prequalification. The scientific and manufacturing capability exists. The vaccine exists. What remains inadequate is the scale and rigour of use.

Vaccination should not be viewed as a substitute for clean water, sanitation, food safety or better diagnostics. It must be part of an integrated typhoid-control strategy.

First, reports of increasing typhoid should trigger strengthened surveillance. Hospitals and laboratories should systematically document suspected and culture-confirmed cases, antimicrobial susceptibil-

ity patterns and prior antibiotic exposure.

Second, diagnostic stewardship needs to become part of antimicrobial stewardship. Blood cultures should ideally be obtained before antibiotics are started, with adequate blood volume and appropriate laboratory practices. India also needs investment in a better point-of-care or rapid diagnostic test for typhoid. We also need to revisit the place of TCV in our public-health strategy.

We should respond to the rising typhoid cases with better diagnostics, stronger surveillance, responsible antimicrobial use and, above all, prevention. India should not have to choose between better diagnosis and vaccination. It needs both.

The writer is senior scientist and programme officer, AMR, ICMR

Typhoid Control Needs More Vaccine, Less Antibiotic

- **It is a life-threatening infection caused by the bacterium Salmonella Typhi.**
- **No animals carry this disease, so transmission is always from human to human.**
- **A person typically contracts typhoid through contaminated food and drinking water.**
- **Once Salmonella Typhi bacteria are ingested, they multiply and spread into the bloodstream.**
- **These bacteria are shed in the stools and urine of infected people.**
- **Typhoid is more prevalent in places with less efficient sanitation and hygiene.**
- **Typhoid fever can be treated with antibiotics. Antimicrobial resistance is a cause of concern**
- **Widal Test is used for testing typhoid**

Thank You